The Sustainability Diet

Accounting for Survivability

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THE PITCH IN ONE LINE

Sustainability describes a food system as it is. But real sustainability — which includes survivability — describes whether it keeps being a food system if the conditions change.

DESCRIPTION

Karen Pendergrass began thinking about the framework that became *The Sustainability Diet* fifteen years ago while watching *The Walking Dead*, asking what would happen to our food systems if there were a zombie apocalypse. The question began unserious. But after fifteen years of pulling on threads through certification audits, fossil records, human-microbiome and heavy-metals research, Paul Martin's late-Pleistocene paleontology, Allan Savory's holistic management, Pollan-Salatin food-systems thinking, and asking what an *antifragile* agricultural system would actually look like, the question seemed more important now than ever. Increasingly so.

The argument is one claim. The standard sustainability framework — economic viability, social fairness, environmental fit — describes how a food system performs under stable conditions. It does not describe how the system performs when the conditions change. *The Sustainability Diet* calls the missing axis *survivability*, builds a four-axis assessment around it, and applies it: industrial grain monoculture, pasture-raised livestock, fisheries, indigenous foodways, urban and bioregional systems, cultivated meat, and closed-loop aquaponics. A late-chapter Case sidebar engages the food-system chokepoints — grain corridors, fertilizer infrastructure, the resilience math behind national security — that have made the survivability axis a real-time diagnostic.

The book engages the contested empirical record on holistic management directly (Briske 2008 and the systematic-review literature). It engages the resilience-thinking field (Holling, Walker, Folke, Berkes) as parallel intellectual lineage — Pendergrass arrived at the framework independently and the book is honest about that. It discloses the author's certification work as professional vantage rather than burying it. And the question ends in another question the book earns the right to ask: *is the food system that scores best on all four axes one the Americas lost twelve and a half thousand years ago, and could we choose to bring back?*

WHERE THIS FITS ON THE LIST

Victory Belt has built a fifteen-year audience around the proposition that the dominant food paradigm is incomplete and that ancestral, pasture-raised, and regenerative alternatives deserve serious consideration. *The Paleo Solution* established the diet. *Sacred Cow* defended pasture in a regenerative system. *The Carnivore Code* took the position to its end. Each of those books makes a *position* claim. None gives the reader a framework for evaluating the next food argument the reader encounters.

The Sustainability Diet is the framework book. It scores why pasture wins where it wins. It treats the carnivore position seriously rather than dismissing it. It gives the audience that bought any of the position-claim books a sharper instrument for thinking about every food argument they encounter, before and after. Audience overlap with the *Sacred Cow* / Robb Wolf reader is functionally complete; the read-through to the *Paleo Solution* and *Carnivore Code* audiences is direct.

The book also brings audiences Victory Belt does not currently capture. Resilience-thinking readers in the Walker & Salt / Taleb intellectual lineage. The *Drawdown* climate-and-food audience. Readers of *The Omnivore's Dilemma* who never made the paleo turn but who will read a framework book. *Yellowstone* and *1883* viewers who have started caring about land-use questions and have not yet been given a way to think about them. Each of those audiences has an entry point on the page.

COMPARABLE TITLES

Sacred Cow — Diana Rodgers & Robb Wolf, BenBella, 2020. Closest in audience and stance; this book is the framework underneath that argument.

The Omnivore's Dilemma — Michael Pollan, Penguin, 2006. Canonical food-systems shelf placement; the framework joins this lineage with a contrarian addition.

Antifragile — Nassim Nicholas Taleb, Random House, 2012. Voice and intellectual register: framework-driven, willing to argue with its own field, ends in a proposition that demands the reader's commitment.

AUDIENCE

Primary: Victory Belt's existing readers. The *Sacred Cow* / Robb Wolf / regenerative-paleo audience already on the shelf. Educated nonfiction readers, 35–65, food-conscious, willing to read framework. Audience overlap with the existing VB backlist is high. **Secondary:** Food-systems readers in the Pollan / Salatin / McKibben tradition. Climate-and-food crossover (the *Drawdown* audience). Resilience-thinking and antifragility crossover. Land-use awareness readers (*Yellowstone* / *1883*) without a current intellectual home.

AUTHOR

Karen Pendergrass founded the Paleo Foundation in 2010 and has spent sixteen years architecting the certification standards behind Paleo Approved, Certified Paleo, Keto Certified, and Heavy Metal Tested & Certified (HMTc). She turned in a manuscript to Victory Belt in 2012. It wasn't good enough to publish. Fourteen years and five restarts later, this is the one that is. Her continuing work on agricultural inputs, soil and gut microbial communities, and metallomic exposure is collected at *wikibiome.com*, *microbiomemedicine.com*, and *heavymetalindex.com*. Available for podcast, speaking, and long-form journalism on launch.

MANUSCRIPT

WORD COUNT	~70,000
PAGE COUNT	293 (typeset, 6×9)
STRUCTURE	Prologue + 13 chapters + Epilogue + Author's Afterword + Technical Appendix
SIDEBARS	33 across seven types (Field Note, Try This, Reversal, Revision, Definition, Case, Source)
FRONT MATTER	Author's Note (publisher pitch) + Disclosure note + four-axis framework diagram
STATUS	Complete; audit-cleared; ready for editorial pass

MARKETING ASSETS & PLATFORM

- **sustainabilitydiet.com** — the title-match domain, owned by the author and already developed as an active site. Direct-traffic on the book's name lands on the author's infrastructure: mailing-list capture, signed-copy fulfillment, podcast/interview reference, and launch landing-page already in place.
- The Paleo Foundation, 15+ years operating: ~600 certified products and the standards behind *Paleo Approved*, *Certified Paleo*, *Keto Certified*, and *HMTc*. Standing relationships across paleo, regenerative-agriculture, and evidence-based-nutrition camps (Robb Wolf, Allan Savory, Walid Abdul-Wahab, and others).
- Additional active sites: paleofoundation.com, wikibiome.com, microbiomemedicine.com, heavymetalindex.com, heavymetaltested.com, karenpendergrass.com. Two Zenodo preprints already positioning the heavy-metals work for public-health-press citation.